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COMMENTARY AND CRITICISM

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Introduction: feminism and food media

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Food media have long been recognized as cultural artifacts that reference culturally- and historically-specific ideals of gender, drawing on the simultaneously mundane and omniscient qualities of food as a medium for interrogating ideas about feminism and identity performance. The increasing popularity of food media throughout the 21st century, as well as the expansion of such media across a variety of genres and platforms, warrants an exploration of the feminist potential encoded within these media.

In this Commentary and Criticism section, the authors introduce a diverse sample of case studies that demonstrate the emergence of feminist ideas in and through food media. Emily Contois explores the ways that celebrities navigate gendered performances through their engagement with hot sauce on the YouTube series *Hot Ones*. Alyxandra Vesey looks at singer Patti LaBelle's food media output as a form of music merchandising, drawing on a history of food work being used to negotiate the parameters of female celebrity. Alexia Smit analyzes the show *Siba's Table*, hosted by South African celebrity chef Siba Mtongana, as an example that exposes and challenges the Western bias and racial assumptions inherent to postfeminist food culture. Danielle Seid examines two 'Asian auntie' cooking web series which can be read as a feminist response to the racialized masculinity of popular Asian celebrity chef food media. Finally, Astrid Schwegler-Castañer discusses the gendered contradictions inherent to the Korean cultural phenomenon of muk-bang, a digital genre involving the live broadcasting of a person eating a large amount of food while interacting with viewers via chat. These essays serve as a reminder of the rich ways that social realities are created and challenged through making and sharing food.

The spicy spectacular: food, gender, and celebrity on *Hot Ones*

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"How are you with hot food?"

So begins *Hot Ones*, a YouTube interview show launched in 2015.[1] In each weekly episode, host Sean Evans interviews a celebrity of varying renown—from Danny Brown and Joey Fatone to Guy Fieri and Neil deGrasse Tyson—as host and guest each eat ten chicken wings dressed with hot sauces of increasing intensity. The show has a significant

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online audience, boasting 2.6 million YouTube subscribers, and the most-watched episode featuring Kevin Hart has more than 12 million views. Bolstered by new media platforms and distribution networks, a novel if offbeat concept, and hot sauce's growing popularity in the U.S., the show aired its one hundredth episode in February 2018.[2] In all that time, only eleven women had been solo guests on the show, a stark underrepresentation that piqued my academic interest. In this brief, feminist analysis of *Hot Ones*, I explore the show's gastronomic strategy for dismantling fame's public façade and creating a sense of "authentic" celebrity (Andrew Tolson 2001; Richard Dyer 2003; Charles Fairchild 2007), which male and female guests navigate in divergent ways. My analysis of *Hot Ones* informs feminist media studies, as it reveals how this YouTube show creates, maintains, and manipulates inequitable gender hierarchies through the interrelated performances of gender, food consumption, and celebrity.

Conventional binary definitions of gender create power hierarchies by feminizing dainty, light, and sweet flavors and foods, eaten in small portions with restraint (Ingrid Kiefer, Theres Rathmanner, and Michael Kunze 2005; Deborah McPhail, Brenda Beagan, and Gwen E. Chapman 2012; Deborah Lupton 1996, 104–5). Conversely, social conventions mark generous portions consumed with gusto, as well as hearty, savory, and *spicy* flavors, as masculine. Food media—including Food Network television shows, restaurant reviews, and chef profiles—reinforce these gendered notions. They present male chef personas, their culinary creations, and food media spaces as bold, innovative, and mobile, while depicting female chefs and their food as comforting, traditional, and confined to the domestic kitchen (Rebecca Swenson 2009; Josée Johnston, Alexandra Rodney, and Phillipa Chong 2014; Charlotte Druckman 2010).

Culturally coded as a masculine food, chicken wings (spicy or not) are situated within "bro" media and spaces, appearing throughout the menus, programming, and advertising at sports bars and at-home football-viewing parties, particularly the Super Bowl (Emily Contois 2018). With regard to spiciness specifically, physiologists assert that testosterone levels influence the consumption of spicy foods, inherently linking masculinity to fiery tastes (Laurent Bègue, Véronique Bricout, Jordane Boudesseul, Rébecca Shankland, and Aaron A. Duke 2015). After finding that men more commonly reported liking spicy foods than women, another study's authors hypothesized that "the cultural association of consuming spicy foods with strength and machismo has created a learned social reward for men" (Nadia K. Byrnes and John E. Hayes 2015, 11). A snarky summary of this study in *The Cut* read, "Women who love hot sauce love hot sauce, men who love hot sauce love being the type of dude who loves hot sauce" (Maggie Lange 2015). Being the type of dude who loves hot sauce is part of performing conventional masculinity, however, through actions like disregarding risk and facing danger fearlessly (R. W. Connell 2005; R. W. Connell and James W. Messerschmidt 2005; Will H. Courtenay 2000). While eating spicy food poses relatively little danger for most eaters, eating hot peppers can be painful, a pain that "real men" are expected to seek out and conquer. Many of the hot sauce brands featured on *Hot Ones* insinuate this challenge with names like the Da' Bomb Beyond Insanity, Original Death Sauce, Mad Dog 357, Zombie Apocalypse, and Pain is Good.

In addition to the masculine coding of chicken wings and spicy tastes, aspects of gender performance may contribute to the underrepresentation of women on *Hot Ones*, who make up just slightly more than 10 percent of guests. Beyond a casting bias, it is possible that fewer women agree to come on the show based on the ways that chewing chicken wings during an interview conflicts with culturally constructed feminine conventions. These include the thin ideal, a restrained appetite, bodily control, and effortless beauty (Susan Bordo 2004; Sandra Lee Bartky 1990), which are only amplified for female celebrities (Susan Bordo 2003; Brenda R. Weber 2012). In addition, *Hot Ones* guests often speak in visceral terms about spicy food's effects on digestion and gastric distress, topics often considered taboo for women to openly discuss, let alone as part of a celebrity persona (Emily Contois 2014).

One way for a female guest to navigate conventions of femininity on *Hot Ones* is to perform the "cool girl" persona. Anne Helen Petersen defines the cool girl as "the way our society implicitly instructs young women on how to be awesome: Be chill and don't be a downer, act like a dude but look like a supermodel" (Petersen 2014). By gnawing on hot wings, swearing through the pain, and dripping sweat, tears, and snot on camera, cool girls triumph on *Hot Ones*, which episode titles acknowledge. "Cara Delevingne Shows Her Hot Sauce Balls While Eating Spicy Wings" ascribes masculinized bravado, while "Rachael Ray Mainlines Hot Sauce for Thanksgiving" recognizes how she skipped the wings altogether and ate the hot sauces straight off spoons. While *Hot Ones* does not explicitly sexualize or objectify female guests, some episode titles reify feminine conventions, such as "Padma Lakshmi Gracefully Destroys Spicy Wings."

Notably, every *Hot Ones* guest performs his or her spicy dexterity against the identity of show host Sean Evans, whose hot sauce mastery—and white, heterosexual, cisgendered, everyman brand of masculinity—anchor the series. Sitting across a simply dressed table with hot sauce bottles down the center, he enthusiastically poses quirky questions to his guest, all the while never struggling to eat all of the wings himself. What makes the show entertaining, however, are moments when guests literally can't stand the heat, or when they at least struggle mightily to do so. In terms of conventional masculinity, weakness in the face of fiery sensation can appear as failure. Of note, the guests who have flunked the wing challenge and earned a spot in the "Hall of Shame" are all men: Jim Gaffigan, D.J. Khaled, Rob Corddry, Mike Epps, and Tony Yayo. The risk of disappointment is arguably lower for female guests.

For cultivating celebrity status (in, through, and around masculinity) however, struggling to eat hot wings while carrying on a conversational interview seems to convey spontaneity, honesty, vulnerability, and authenticity—as long as male guests successfully complete the challenge in the end. For female guests, this "authentic" aspect of celebrity management—achieved through the public consumption of spicy wings—remains linked to the coolness of particular personae. In addition to the underrepresentation of women on *Hot Ones*, the structure of the show's entertainment value in effect limits the program's promotional power to only some brands of female celebrity, as the show reinforces gendered definitions of food, flavor, and appetite.

Notes

1. *Hot Ones* was developed by Chris Schonberger, produced by Complex Network and First We Feast, and is hosted by Sean Evans.
2. The U.S. hot sauce market grew 150% between 2000 and 2014, and steadily every year since, indicative of the culinary influence of Latin American and south and east Asian immigration (Roberto A. Ferdman and Ritchie King 2014; Chase Purdy 2017).

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Four-octave range and five-star cuisine: Patti LaBelle in the kitchen and the gender politics of music merchandising

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Since *The French Chef*'s debut in 1963, food television has used the kitchen to negotiate the parameters of contemporary female celebrity. For decades, many stand-and-stir hostesses were chefs and cookbook authors who became celebrities for television audiences. More recently, cable programmers have hired social media celebrities and entertainers who reinvent themselves as home cooks. Singers contribute to this second strategy. Yet such programming trends are a recent iteration of female-identified musicians' tactical use of food branding for career longevity in an industry that often uses sexism and ageism to limit their commercial prospects. Cookbook authorship connects singer Patti LaBelle to musical food television personalities like Trisha Yearwood and Kelis. Before becoming the host and executive producer of *Patti LaBelle's Place* for the Cooking Channel (2015-present), LaBelle co-wrote three cookbooks that supplemented and extended her nearly sixty-year musical career.

Such work resembles the authorship film historian Amelie Hastie identifies in early film stars' personal archives. Hastie defines these women as authors who document their professional experiences and demonstrate expertise in the industry they helped create (2007, 11). Ultimately LaBelle's food work is best understood as music merchandising, or